Supporting an Inclusive Educational Environment

Wentao Zhang · Application for Tenure-Track Faculty Position in Physical AI
Bradley Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering, Virginia Tech

---

The Virginia Tech Principles of Community ask each member of the university to **respect the dignity of every person** and to recognize that **individual differences strengthen the community**. I share that view, and I would join Virginia Tech with humility: as a newcomer, my first commitment is to **listen to and learn from colleagues and students** who understand this community far better than I do, and to contribute alongside them rather than presume to redesign work they have built over many years.

Experiences That Shaped My Commitment

My understanding of inclusion is rooted in my own path as an **international scholar**. I completed my degrees in China and now work in the United Kingdom, and I have experienced firsthand what it is to learn, present, and collaborate in an unfamiliar academic culture and a second language. That experience gives me genuine empathy for **international and first-generation students**, who often have the ability but not yet the local context or confidence, and it has taught me to be patient, explicit, and welcoming when explaining expectations that insiders take for granted.

My research has been **collaborative and cross-cultural by nature**. I have worked closely with colleagues across different institutions and countries, co-authored with researchers from a range of backgrounds and career stages, and I help organize an international special session at ICEM 2026 that brings researchers together across the field. In each setting I have tried to make sure that quieter or more junior contributors are heard and that credit is shared fairly, which I consider a basic and practical form of inclusion.

I have also mentored junior PhD and MS students with very different levels of preparation. The most useful thing I have learned is to **meet each student where they are**, adjusting how much structure and explanation I provide, so that a student's starting point does not limit how far they can go.

Plans for Supporting Inclusive Excellence at Virginia Tech

In the **classroom**, I would teach in ways that lower needless barriers: stating expectations and assessment criteria transparently, offering multiple ways for students to engage with material, providing accessible notes and worked examples, and inviting questions without judgment. I would treat the diversity of student preparation as something to design for, not around.

In **research and mentoring**, I would run a group with clear expectations, regular individual support, and fair attribution of work, and I would actively recruit and support students from groups underrepresented in engineering and AI. I would seek to involve undergraduates in research early, including through pathways such as **NSF Research Experiences for Undergraduates**, which can be especially valuable for students who have not previously seen research as open to them.

In the **broader community**, I would support, rather than duplicate, the College of Engineering's established efforts. Virginia Tech has a long record in this area through its **Center for Engineering Excellence and Discovery (CEED)** and its established pre-college and undergraduate student programs. I would be glad to contribute as a faculty mentor or instructor where helpful, to learn from the colleagues who lead this work, and to make my own laboratory a welcoming entry point for students exploring Physical AI.

Respect and Collegiality

Finally, I see an inclusive environment as inseparable from **everyday collegiality**: assuming good faith, giving credit generously, disagreeing respectfully on technical matters, and supporting colleagues and students through difficult periods. I would aim to be the kind of colleague who makes the department a place where people from any background feel respected and able to do their best work, and I would consider it a privilege to support and extend Virginia Tech's commitment to inclusive excellence.